

Customer Service Runbook

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How to use this runbook

This runbook is for anyone at Northwind Traders who answers a customer by telephone or email. Each section covers one situation. Every section has the same four parts: what the situation is, what to check in the order system, what the rule is, and what to do.

The runbook repeats the most important limits from the policies so that you can work from one page. If the runbook and a policy ever disagree, the policy is right and the runbook is wrong. Please report the difference to Laura Callahan.

Always read order, stock and price data from the live system at the moment you need it. Never rely on a figure you remember or a figure written in a memo.

Situation 1: The customer asks for a rush order

The situation. The customer needs an order sooner than planned and asks whether it can be expedited.

What to check. Open the order. Check that the shipped date is empty. Note the required date, the carrier, and the freight amount. Then check the units in stock for the product on every line.

The rule. An order may be expedited when it has not shipped, when its required date is no more than 5 calendar days away or has already passed, and when every line can be filled from stock. For the key accounts QUICK-Stop, Ernst Handel and Save-a-lot Markets the window is 10 calendar days. The rule is in the Order Expedite and Shipping Policy (NW-POL-002).

What to do. If the order meets all three conditions, tell the customer that the surcharge is 40 percent of the freight on the order. Key accounts are not charged. If the freight on the order is 50.00 or less you may agree the expedite yourself. If it is above 50.00, send the request to the Sales Approvals queue. The Sales Manager approves up to 250.00 and the Vice President, Sales approves above that. If the order does not meet the conditions, explain which condition failed. Do not promise an expedite before it has been approved.

Situation 2: The customer complains that an order arrived late

The situation. An order has shipped, and the customer says it arrived after the date they needed it.

What to check. Compare the shipped date with the required date. An order is late when the shipped date is after the required date.

The rule. When an order was late because of Northwind, the freight on that order is refunded in full. The refund needs the same approval as an expedite: none up to 50.00, the Sales Manager above 50.00 and up to 250.00, and the Vice President, Sales above 250.00.

What to do. Apologise, and confirm the two dates to the customer. Send the refund request to the Sales Approvals queue if it needs approval. If the shipped date was on or before the required date, the order was not late under this rule, even if the carrier was slow. In that case pass the complaint to logistics@northwind.example so that it can be raised with the carrier.

Situation 3: An order is overdue and has not shipped

The situation. The required date has passed and the order is still in the warehouse.

What to check. Check the stock for every line to find out what is holding the order. Check whether the customer accepts partial shipments. For key accounts this is in the account notes.

The rule. The salesperson on the order must contact the customer within 1 business day. An overdue order is inside the expedite window, so it may be expedited if every line can be filled.

What to do. Contact the customer, explain the delay and offer the options that apply: expedite the order, ship the lines that are available, reduce a line, or accept an approved substitute. Record the customer's decision on the order.

Situation 4: A line cannot be filled from stock

The situation. The quantity on a line is higher than the units in stock.

What to check. Check whether the product is discontinued. Check the supplier's country.

The rule. For a product that is not discontinued, you may promise a date equal to today, plus the standard lead time for the supplier's country, plus 2 days for receiving. The standard lead times are 7 days for the USA and Canada, 14 days for Europe, and 21 days for Japan, Singapore, Australia and Brazil. The rule is in the Reorder and Supplier Lead-Time Policy (NW-POL-005).

What to do. Tell the customer the date you can promise. If that date is after the required date, offer a partial shipment where the customer accepts one. Never quote a date that is earlier than the rule allows, even if units are already on order.

Situation 5: The customer orders a discontinued product

The situation. A line is for a product that Northwind no longer buys.

What to check. Confirm that the product is flagged as discontinued in the product master. Check the units in stock.

The rule. Remaining stock is sold until it is gone, and the line may not be higher than the units in stock. There are no backorders. You may give a clearance discount of up to 15 percent on your own authority on such a line. When the stock cannot cover the line, you may offer only the approved substitute for the quantity that is missing, and only with the customer's consent. The rule is in the Discontinued Product and Substitution Guide (NW-POL-003).

What to do. If there is enough stock, confirm the line. If there is some stock, offer the remaining quantity, and the approved substitute for the rest. If there is none, offer the approved substitute. A substitute is sold at its own list price. If the guide lists no approved substitute, do not suggest one. Send the request to purchasing@northwind.example.

Situation 6: The customer asks for a bigger discount

The situation. The customer asks for a discount that is above your own authority.

What to check. Work out the total discount on the line, including any contract discount or promotion the customer already has.

The rule. You may agree up to 10 percent yourself. The Sales Manager approves above 10 percent and up to 20 percent. The Vice President, Sales approves above 20 percent and up to 25 percent. Northwind does not give more than 25 percent. The rule is in the Discount Authority Policy (NW-POL-001).

What to do. Do not confirm the discount to the customer until the approval is recorded in the Sales Approvals queue. Tell the customer when you expect an answer. Northwind does not approve discounts after the order has been confirmed.

Situation 7: The carrier on an order is wrong for the goods

The situation. An unshipped order with chilled goods is assigned to a carrier that may not carry them.

What to check. Check the category of the product on every line and the carrier on the order.

The rule. Dairy Products and Meat/Poultry may ship only with Speedy Express or United Package. Seafood may ship only with Speedy Express. The strictest line decides for the whole order. The rule is in the Perishables Handling and Carrier Guide (NW-POL-004).

What to do. Report the order to logistics@northwind.example. Logistics changes the carrier to the cheapest one that is allowed. The customer is not charged and no approval is needed.

Situation 8: The customer wants to change the delivery address

The situation. The customer asks for an order to go to a different address.

What to check. Check whether the order has shipped.

The rule. The address may be changed until the order has shipped. If the new address is in a different country, the freight must be quoted again before the change is confirmed. After the order has shipped, the address cannot be changed.

What to do. Make the change, or explain why it is not possible. If the freight changes, confirm the new amount with the customer in writing before you save the change.

Situation 9: The customer wants to return goods

The situation. The customer wants to send goods back or reports damaged goods.

What to check. Check the shipped date and the category of each product.

The rule. Ambient goods may be returned within 14 days of the shipped date if they are unopened. Chilled goods are never returned physically. The customer must report a problem with chilled goods within 48 hours of delivery and send photographs. Northwind then issues a credit.

What to do. For ambient goods, send the customer a return label. For chilled goods, ask for the photographs and pass them to logistics@northwind.example, which confirms the credit.

Who to contact

- Approvals for discounts, expedites and freight refunds: the Sales Approvals queue, sales-approvals@northwind.example.

- Carrier, packing and delivery problems: logistics@northwind.example.
- Stock, suppliers and substitutes: purchasing@northwind.example.
- Questions about this runbook: Laura Callahan, Inside Sales Coordinator.